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UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
NORTHERN DISTRICT OF CALIFORNIA
SAN FRANCISCO DIVISION

TSI AKIM MAIDU OF TAYLORSVILLE RANCHERIA,

Plaintiff,

v.

UNITED STATES DEPARTMENT OF THE INTERIOR; RYAN ZINKE, in his official capacity as Secretary of the Interior; MICHAEL S. BLACK, in his official capacity as Acting Assistant Secretary-Indian Affairs of the United States Department of the Interior; and DOES 1 to 100,

Defendants.

Case No. 16-cv-7189-LB

MOTION TO DISMISS OR TRANSFER FOR IMPROPER VENUE OR, IN THE ALTERNATIVE, MOTION TO DISMISS FOR FAILURE TO STATE A CLAIM

Date: Thursday, May 25, 2017
Time: 9:30 a.m.
Place: Courtroom C, 15th Floor
Hon. Laurel Beeler

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NOTICE OF MOTION

PLEASE TAKE NOTICE that on Thursday, May 25, 2017, at 9:30 a.m., or as soon thereafter as the matter may be heard, in Courtroom C, 15th Floor, before the Honorable Laurel Beeler, Defendants, United States Department of the Interior, Ryan Zinke, in his official capacity as Secretary of the Interior, and Michael S. Black, in his official capacity as Acting Assistant Secretary-Indian Affairs of the United States Department of the Interior,[1] will move to dismiss for improper venue pursuant to Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 12(b)(3) or to transfer this case pursuant to 28 U.S.C. § 1406(a) to a district where it could have been brought. Plaintiff, who resides in the Eastern District of California, has filed this action to challenge a determination by the Department of the Interior in Washington, D.C. Thus, because this case does not have a connection to the Northern District of California, the Court should either dismiss or transfer this action to the U.S. District Court for the Eastern District of California or the District of Columbia. In the alternative, Defendants move pursuant to Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 12(b)(6) for an order dismissing Plaintiff's complaint for failure to state a claim. Defendants base this motion on this notice, the accompanying memorandum of points and authorities, the Court's files and records in this matter, and other matters of which the Court takes judicial notice, and any oral argument that may be presented to the Court.

RELIEF SOUGHT

Defendants seek an order dismissing this action for lack of proper venue or an order of transfer to the United States District Court for the Eastern District of California or the District of Columbia. Alternatively, Defendants seek an order dismissing the claims asserted in Plaintiff's complaint for failure to state a claim.

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[1] Pursuant to Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 25(d), Secretary of the Interior Ryan Zinke and Acting Assistant Secretary-Indian Affairs Michael S. Black are automatically substituted for former Secretary Sarah Jewell and former Deputy Assistant Secretary Lawrence S. Roberts, respectively, as the defendants in this action.

ISSUES TO BE DECIDED

1. Whether this action should be dismissed or transferred because Plaintiff has failed to establish that venue in the Northern District of California is proper.

2. Whether dismissal is appropriate because Plaintiff has failed to identify any agency action that is legally required.

3. Whether dismissal is appropriate because Plaintiff's claims are barred by the applicable statute of limitations.

MEMORANDUM OF POINTS AND AUTHORITIES

I. INTRODUCTION

In this action, Plaintiff, Tsi Akim Maidu of Taylorsville Rancheria, purports to challenge a June 2015 letter from then-Assistant Secretary-Indian Affairs Kevin K. Washburn addressing the termination of the Federal relationship with the Plaintiff when the United States sold the Taylorsville Rancheria in 1966 pursuant to Congressional mandate. Although Plaintiff refers to itself as a California Indian Tribe, Plaintiff does not appear on the Department of the Interior's list of federally recognized Indian tribes and is not recognized as an Indian tribe by the United States. *See* 25 U.S.C. § 5131; 82 Fed. Reg. 4,915 (Jan. 17, 2017). Plaintiff seeks a writ of mandamus and declaratory and injunctive relief against the Department of the Interior, the Secretary of the Interior, and the Acting Assistant Secretary-Indian Affairs (collectively, "Defendants"), and asks this Court to compel Defendants to find that Plaintiff never lost its status as a federally recognized Indian tribe.

As Plaintiff's own pleading reflects, a substantial part of the events or omissions giving rise to Plaintiff's claims occurred "near," but not in, the Northern District of California. Because Plaintiff cannot otherwise establish that venue is proper in this district under 28 U.S.C. § 1391(e)(1), the Court should dismiss this case for improper venue or transfer it to the Eastern District of California or the District of Columbia.

In the alternative, dismissal of this action pursuant to Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 12(b)(6) for failure to state a claim is warranted. The crux of this action—Plaintiff's claim that it is entitled to an order compelling Defendants to confer Federal recognition upon it—is subject to dismissal for two independent reasons. First, Plaintiff cannot identify any source of law that imposes upon the Department of the Interior a duty to add the Plaintiff to the list of federally recognized tribes and therefore has not plead any agency action that is wrongfully withheld. Moreover, Plaintiff's claims first accrued well outside the six-year statute of limitations applicable to civil actions brought against the United States, and are therefore barred. Accordingly, for the reasons explained below, Defendants respectfully request that the Court dismiss or transfer this action for improper venue or, in the alternative, dismiss this action for failure to state a claim.

II. FACTUAL BACKGROUND

Plaintiff, Tsi Akim Maidu of Taylorsville Rancheria, claims to be a "California Indian Tribe" that is included in the Northeastern Maidu group (aka Mountain Maidu) in Plumas County. Compl. ¶ 18. Plaintiff occupied the American, Genesee, and Indian valleys in what is now Plumas County. *Id.*

In 1958, Congress enacted the California Rancheria Act, 72 Stat. 619, which authorized the Secretary to terminate federal recognition of 41 California Rancherias. Plaintiff was not specifically named as one of the 41 rancherias to be sold. *See id.* In 1964, Congress amended the California Rancheria Act to authorized the Secretary to sell vacant California Rancherias. 78 Stat. 390 (1964). The Act required the Secretary to sell vacant Rancherias held for California Indians generally, and deposit the money to the interest of California Indians. *See* Section 5(d), 78 Stat. 390, 391 (1964). The Act authorized the Secretary to sell vacant Rancherias held for "a named tribe, band, or group," with proceeds deposited to the credit of the named entity. *See id.* When the Secretary sold Taylorsville Rancheria in 1966, the proceeds were deposited to the

credit of the California Indians, *see* Compl. ¶ 10, establishing that the Secretary did not consider the Indians associated with the Taylorsville Rancheria to be "a named tribe, band, or group."

In 1998, Plaintiff submitted a letter of intent to petition for acknowledgment as a federally recognized Indian tribe under the Department of the Interior's "Procedures for Establishing that An American Indian Group Exists As An Indian Tribe" set forth in 25 C.F.R. 83 ("Part 83 procedures"). Compl. ¶ 4. The Part 83 process is the uniform procedure instituted by the Department of the Interior by which an entity may seek formal federal recognition and sets forth the criteria necessary for acknowledgment as a federally recognized Indian tribe. 25 C.F.R. § 83.11, 80 Fed. Reg. 37,889 (July 1, 2015). The regulations are applicable "only to indigenous entities that are not federally recognized Indian tribes." 25 C.F.R. § 83.3, 80 Fed. Reg. 37,888 (July 1, 2015). Plaintiff then sought clarification from the Department of the Interior about its status as a federally recognized Indian Tribe. Compl. ¶ 11. In a letter dated June 9, 2015, then-Assistant Secretary-Indian Affairs Washburn responded that Defendants had sold the Taylorsville Rancheria on November 4, 1966 to Plumas County pursuant to Section 5(d) of the amended California Rancheria Act as a vacant rancheria, and that the sale of the Taylorsville Rancheria was equivalent to Congressional termination of the federal relationship with the Plaintiff. *Id.* ¶ 25.

Plaintiff alleges that the sale of the Taylorsville Rancheria did not legally terminate its status as an Indian tribe. *Id.* ¶ 28. Plaintiff has brought this action claiming that Defendants violated its "statutory rights" by refusing to recognize Plaintiff's members as Indians, *id.* ¶¶ 26-30, unlawfully interpreted the California Rancheria Act, *id.* ¶¶ 31-36, and unlawfully denied the status of Plaintiff as a federally recognized tribe because of the alleged misinterpretation of the California Rancheria Act, *id.* ¶¶ 35-37.

III. ARGUMENT

A. This Case Should Be Dismissed or Transferred Because Venue in the Northern District of California Is Improper

1. Legal Standard

Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 12(b)(3) provides that a defendant may seek to dismiss an action for improper venue. The plaintiff bears the burden of demonstrating that venue is proper. *Munson v. California*, No. C 08-5053 SBA, 2009 WL 264838, at *1 (N.D. Cal. Feb. 4, 2009) (citation omitted). On a Rule 12(b)(3) motion, "the pleadings need not be accepted as true, and the court may consider facts outside of the pleadings," but the court must draw all reasonable inferences and resolve all factual conflicts in favor of the non-moving party. *Murphy v. Schneider Nat'l, Inc.*, 362 F.3d 1133, 1137 (9th Cir. 2004). In an action against an agency of the United States or an officer or employee of the United States acting in his official capacity, venue is proper in any judicial district in which: (A) a defendant resides; (B) a substantial part of the events or omissions giving rise to the claim occurred or a substantial part of the property that is the subject of the action is situated; or (C) the plaintiff resides if no real property is involved in the action. 28 U.S.C. § 1391(e)(1). *Animal Legal Def. Fund v. U.S. Dep't of Agric.*, No. CV 12-4407-SC, 2013 WL 120185, at *1-2 (N.D. Cal. Jan. 8, 2013).

2. Dismissal Is Appropriate Because This District Is Not A Proper Venue

Here, Plaintiff cannot establish venue in the Northern District of California under 28 U.S.C. § 1391(e). To begin, Plaintiff suggests that venue is proper under § 1391(e)(1)(B) because "a substantial part of the events or omissions giving rise to Plaintiff's claims occurred near this District." Compl. ¶ 2 (emphasis added). The complaint further alleges that Plaintiff is "included in the Northeastern Maidu group (aka Mountain Maidu) in Plumas County" and that it "occupied the American, Genesee, and Indian valleys in what is now the Plumas County." *Id.* ¶ 18. The occurrence of events or omissions giving rise to Plaintiff's claims in proximity to this

district—specifically, in Plumas County in the neighboring Eastern District of California[2]—does not confer venue in the Northern District of California. Nor can Plaintiff satisfy either of the other bases for venue under § 1391(e)(1). For purposes of § 1391(e)(1)(A), federal government defendants do not reside in every judicial district in which an agency has an office, but instead are generally deemed to reside in the District of Columbia. *Reuben H. Donnelly Corp. v. FTC*, 580 F.2d 264, 267 (7th Cir. 1978); *Williams v. United States*, No. C-01-0024, 2001 WL 1352885, at *1 (N.D. Cal. Oct. 23, 2001). As to § 1391(e)(1)(C), Plaintiff has identified on the Civil Cover Sheet its county of residence as Plumas County in the Eastern District of California. *See* ECF No. 2. Thus, the Northern District of California is not a proper venue under § 1391(e)(1) and, consequently, Plaintiff's complaint should be dismissed.

3. In the Alternative, the Court Should Transfer This Case

If venue is improper, the district court has the discretion to either dismiss the case or, in the interests of justice, to transfer the case to a district where it could have been brought. *King v. Russell*, 963 F.2d 1301, 1304 (9th Cir. 1992); 28 U.S.C. § 1406(a). This case could have been brought in either the Eastern District of California, where the Plaintiff resides, or the District of Columbia, where the Defendants reside and from where the June 9, 2015 letter issued. Accordingly, if the Court determines that the interests of justice would be served, the Court should transfer this case to the Eastern District of California or the District of Columbia.

[2] *See* http://www.caed.uscourts.gov/caednew/index.cfm/cmecf-e-filing/jurisdiction-and-venue/ (last visited Apr. 17, 2017) ("All civil and criminal actions and proceedings of every nature and kind cognizable in the United States District Court for the Eastern District of California arising in . . . Plumas . . . counties shall be commenced in the United States District Court sitting [in] Sacramento, California, and in Redding, California, or other designated places within those counties as the Court shall designate when appropriate for Magistrate Judge criminal proceedings.").

B. Alternatively, the Court Should Dismiss This Action for Failure to State a Claim

1. Legal Standard

A motion to dismiss under Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 12(b)(6) tests the legal sufficiency of the claims alleged in a complaint. *N. Star Int'l v. Ariz. Corp. Comm'n*, 720 F.2d 578, 581 (9th Cir. 1983). To survive a 12(b)(6) motion to dismiss, "a complaint must contain sufficient factual matter, accepted as true, to 'state a claim to relief that is plausible on its face.'" *Ashcroft v. Iqbal*, 556 U.S. 662, 678 (2009) (quoting *Bell Atl. Corp. v. Twombly*, 550 U.S. 544, 570 (2007)). A dismissal under Rule 12(b)(6) may be based on the lack of a cognizable legal theory or on the absence of sufficient facts alleged under a cognizable legal theory. *Johnson v. Riverside Healthcare Sys.*, 534 F.3d 1116, 1121 (9th Cir. 2008); *Navarro v. Block*, 250 F.3d 729, 732 (9th Cir. 2001); *Balistreri v. Pacifica Police Dep't*, 901 F.2d 696, 699 (9th Cir. 1990). While a pleading does not require "detailed factual allegations," it must do more than merely offer "labels and conclusions" or "a formulaic recitation of the elements of a cause of action" without "further factual enhancement." *Iqbal*, 556 U.S. at 678 (internal quotation marks omitted) (citing *Twombly*, 550 U.S. at 555). A complaint that consists only of "[t]hreadbare recitals of the elements of a cause of action, supported by mere conclusory statements" is subject to dismissal under Rule 12(b)(6). *Iqbal*, 556 U.S. at 678. "Where a complaint pleads facts that are 'merely consistent with' a defendant's liability, it 'stops short of the line between possibility and plausibility of entitlement to relief.'" *Id.* (quoting *Twombly*, 550 U.S. at 557). Courts construe the allegations in the complaint in the light most favorable to the non-moving party and all material allegations in the complaint are taken to be true. *Sanders v. Kennedy*, 794 F.2d 478, 481 (9th Cir. 1986). However, a court is not required to accept as true conclusory allegations that are contradicted by documents referred to in the complaint, unreasonable inferences, or unwarranted deductions of fact. *Manzarek v. St. Paul Fire & Marine Ins. Co.*, 519 F.3d 1025, 1031 (9th Cir. 2008).

CONCLUSION

For the reasons set forth above, Defendants respectfully request that the Court dismiss or transfer this action for lack of proper venue or, in the alternative, dismiss the action for failure to state a claim.

Dated: April 20, 2017

Respectfully submitted,

BRIAN J. STRETCH
United States Attorney

/s/ Michelle Lo
Michelle Lo
Assistant United States Attorney
Counsel for Defendants